

Sport both makes and unmakes champions

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Suresh Menon

My wife reacted the way millions must have when they heard the news of Tiger Woods's most recent car crash (while driving under the influence): "What, again?"

The bad boys of sport seem to have what Shakespearean heroes have in his tragedies — hamartia, a word that roughly translates to 'fatal flaw'. This causes a fall from grace as with Macbeth (ambition), Hamlet (indecision) or Othello (jealousy). In sport it is usually alcohol, drugs and sex.

Yet, such weakness make for great theatre or indeed fascinating athletes. They stray, stumble, fall and so leave behind a story richer than a column of statistics. Sport is not always about excellence; it is about excess, about frailty, about genius and imperfection in the same person. Sport both makes and unmakes champions.

I always found Woods (**in pic**) more fascinating than Jack Nicklaus, Boris Becker more than Ivan Lendl. **The same intensity that drives a man to dominate his sport can also drive him to excess. The same confidence that allows him to attempt the impossible can lead him to believe he is immune to consequence.**

At his peak, Woods was a force of nature. Courses did not defeat him, they merely delayed him. Fame arrived early and settled heavily. He was surrounded by a fawning media that covered up his foibles, so when it all began to unravel, it came as a shock to many. But those who knew him saw the inevitability. The path had been



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taken by many before him.

Like the footballer George Best. I never saw him in action, but I devoured anything written about him when I was a boy. I remember reading about how he could place a coin on the heel of a bent leg and flip it into either shirt pocket at will. Imagination provided the visual. Was the story true? No idea, but it should have been.

The Woods story is compelling not much for the fall as for the comebacks. When he crashed in 2017 (he fell asleep at the wheel after ingesting prescription drugs) fans feared he might never walk again. Yet two years later he won the Masters. He had had a spinal fusion surgery. Two years after that he was found upside down in a ravine having driven his car into it at some speed. When the vehicle had to be cut through to pull him out, one of those present said he was lucky to be alive.

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There is a tendency to moralise about men like Woods, but sport does not produce saints; it produces supremely gifted human beings who are placed under extraordinary pressure. We demand perfection, but are drawn to its opposite.

Woods is 50, and with his record of car crashes drunk or sober, there is one thing he should do with some urgency. Hire a driver.